

macy. Despite a long career in diplomacy, Jaishankar has built a reputation for avoiding the frills of the diplomatic job, diving straight into the issue at hand.

When Jaishankar took on the mantle of foreign minister, he could not have anticipated that a pandemic, a conflict with China and a Russia-Ukraine war would turn the world on its head. It fell on him to help steer India through probably the toughest period in its history—keeping India's interests foremost, while negotiating a world that suddenly looked very different. One of Jaishankar's oldest friends Ashley Tellis, a senior fellow and inaugural chair at the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, says, "He is both incredibly intelligent and perceptive—able to read situations astutely to find opportunities to advance India's interests. And he has a great sense of humour that is simply disarming in even the trickiest of circumstances."

Whether it was keeping supply chains open for India's pharmaceutical industry and its vaccine production, or ensuring that Indian vaccines reached 66 countries in dire need—India's foreign policy pirouetted into action. India sent hydroxy-chloroquine to far ends of the world, made certain the food corridor to the Gulf states remained active through the global lockdown. When Paraguay was told by China that it would get Chinese vaccines if they gave up their relationship with Taiwan, India took their call and despatched vaccines to a remote corner of the world.

NAVIGATING CHAOS

The India-China conflict of 2020 had a very different flavour. It fell to Jaishankar and his ministry to negotiate our way through the unprecedented conflict.

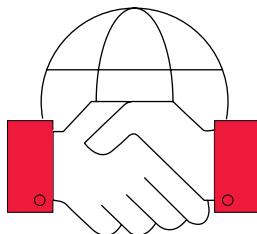
India lost 20 men in a most unusual clash in Galwan and had to craft a response that went beyond the military. As foreign secretary, Jaishankar had dealt with the Doklam crisis of 2017. As minister, Jaishankar was confronted with the fact that not only did China's actions destroy three decades of careful diplomacy, but that as neighbours India needed to deal with the China challenge very differ-

GIFT OF THE GAB

01 **Jaishankar reflects a blend of academic rigour, extensive field experience, and a forward-looking approach to India's foreign policy challenges**

02 **As minister, he was confronted with the fact that China's actions would destroy three decades of careful diplomacy**

03 **Jaishankar's great gift has turned out to be his unique ability to bring convergence to almost irreconcilable notions**



ently. Patient diplomacy was the answer, and India became an early adopter of the "decoupling from China" argument, restricting investment and refusing China access to Indian data. On the other hand, he worked hard to normalise relations with a disengagement at the points of conflict while reopening channels of communication.

Jaishankar's great gift has turned out to be his unique ability to bring convergence to almost irreconcilable notions. India and the US are charting a future together as technology partners, even as both sides differed on their approach to Russia and the Ukraine war. India has kept the Russia relationship alive and continued to buy Russian oil in the teeth of western criticism and pressure.

After the October 7 Hamas attack on Israel, India has maintained a very nuanced stand — as Jaishankar explained, "there are different dimensions, different elements to this. Number one, we must be clear that what happened on October 7th was terrorism. No caveats, no justification, no explanation. It was terrorism. Number two, as Israel responds, it is important that Israel should have been very mindful of civilian casualties, that it has an obligation to observe international humanitarian law. Number three, the return of hostages is imperative. Number four, there is a need for a humanitarian corridor, a sustainable humanitarian corridor to provide relief. And eventually, there has to be a permanent fix, a long-term fix, otherwise we're going to see a recurrence. India has long believed in a two-state solution; we have maintained that position for many decades. Today, many more countries in the world feel not just that a two-state solution is necessary, but it is more urgent".

Indian diplomacy has traditionally excelled in walking diplomatic tightropes, but as the stakes for India have grown and the world has become more complex, this has required a different level of dexterity.

But as he said in Europe in 2024, "I don't want you to even inadvertently give the impression that we are purely and unsentimentally transactional. We are not. We get